

Super Mario on the loose

送信者: POLITICO Brussels Playbook 受信日時: 2026-08-26 13:57

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POLITICO's must-read briefing on what's driving the day in Brussels, by Gerardo Fortuna, Nicholas Vinocur and Gabriel Gavin. By GERARDO FORTUNA CIAO T

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CIAO THERE. It's Gerardo Fortuna with a heavy heart after the death of Dolly Parton — phenomenal songwriter and author of arguably the best American take on EU politics to date. When asked about Brexit on a red carpet, she said: "We can't hardly even take care of our own problems, much less try to solve yours."

In today's Playbook:

- António Costa's capitals roadshow has already hit its first agricultural bump.
- The Channel Tunnel is set to get a lot busier by the end of the decade.
- Faces in the crowd: Robert Fico, Ursula von der Leyen, Mark Carney, Roberta Metsola, Nicolas Petit, Carl XVI Gustaf and Victoria of Sweden, Mario Draghi, Gideon Sa'ar, Pedro Sánchez, Jim Hagemann Snabe, Bernard Quintin, Grzegorz Braun, Jean Spinette and more.

On today's Brussels Playbook Podcast: Zoya and Ian unpack the latest clash between the EU's two economic powerhouses, Germany and France, over how best to revive European industry.

DRIVING THE DAY

DRAGHI UNCHAINED: European Commission officials have started grappling with an awkward question: What if golden boy Mario Draghi is going rogue?

Borrowed clout: Choosing the former European Central Bank president to diagnose — and prescribe a cure for — Europe's economic woes gave Ursula von der Leyen political cover to push capitals to spend more, integrate their economies and surrender some national control.

But Draghi is his own man. With the Italian economist putting his weight behind the Rhine Group — which, as Playbook reported yesterday, is a new organization of 54 CEOs, economists, academics and tech entrepreneurs that wants to develop reforms outside the EU machinery — officials sense that the relationship's honeymoon period is long over.

The Commission was caught off guard: It didn't know the Rhine Group was coming, despite von der Leyen speaking to Draghi just last month. "They didn't speak much about work," an EU official said when asked why she wasn't given a heads-up.

"Unpredictable," was how another Commission official described Draghi. (Like others we spoke to, the official was granted anonymity to talk candidly about how the initiative went down behind closed doors.)

Er, great idea, Mario! Publicly, the Commission didn't criticize the initiative but didn't exactly give a full-throated endorsement either. Boosting Europe's long-term competitiveness means mobilizing massive private investment alongside simpler rules, was Commission spokesperson Arianna Podestà's reaction. "Private sector initiatives are key in this sense." Some reading between the lines is necessary, we think.

So what? The Commission still needs Draghi's pressure on governments to implement his landmark competitiveness report. But his new vehicle is able to push the same agenda independently of Brussels — and risks adding to scrutiny of how much von der Leyen has actually delivered. (Clue: Not as much as many would hope .)

No falling out: Two Commission officials played down talk of rivalry, arguing Draghi's clout keeps competitiveness high on the agenda and helps the EU executive tell reluctant capitals they can't cherry-pick his recommendations.

But but but ... An EU official said it's awkward that Draghi appears to be "emancipating" himself from the Commission and von der Leyen. Another EU official went further: "If I were prof. Draghi, I would be disappointed, if not upset" after von der Leyen courted Parliament votes on the back of his report, hailed the roadmap she built on it as Europe's competitiveness "North Star" and created a dedicated task force. "Eight months later, a German bureaucrat [Heinz Jansen] was put at the head of that task with no force ... and the steam was gone." Draghi's spokesperson declined to comment on the Rhine Group initiative.

Skippping Brussels: European University Institute professor Nicolas Petit, an initiator and member of the Rhine Group, told POLITICO's Francesca Micheletti that the initiative "may work on other ways of getting things done," including cooperation among countries prepared to move ahead without waiting for everyone else.

Too close for comfort? Jim Hagemann Snabe, Siemens chair and von der Leyen's special envoy for industrial AI, initially appeared on the Rhine Group's membership page but was removed. Commission spokesperson Balazs Ujvari told POLITICO's Pieter Haeck that Snabe had been invited to a specific meeting but "will not take up a formal role."

BIG AND BREAKING

HOW TO FIX FRANCE'S DEBT CRISIS: Far-left presidential contender Jean-Luc Mélenchon wants the European Central Bank to waive interest payments on a huge chunk of France's public debt — or, in his words, to "set fire" to it .

CARNEY'S ALLIANCE OF ONE: Seven months after Canadian PM Mark Carney urged middle powers to unite against economic coercion, Ottawa is fighting a trade war with Washington largely alone .

ANOTHER PARIS-BERLIN SCRAP: France wants tougher “Made in Europe” requirements in the EU’s landmark Industrial Accelerator Act , but Germany worries they’ll provoke retaliation from trading partners.

CHECK YOUR NOTIFICATIONS: State-backed hackers are targeting the WhatsApp accounts of high-ranking EU officials with tailor-made lures, according to an internal warning from the bloc’s cyber defense unit obtained by POLITICO’s Sam Clark.

CEUTA BLAME GAME: Pedro Sánchez’s ministers are now clashing over whether Madrid ignored intelligence warnings before some 72,000 migrants poured into the Spanish exclave last month.

FICO’S BUDGET DEMANDS

FIRST RESPONSE FROM THE CAPITALS: António Costa takes his capitals tour to Riga and Vilnius today with the first farm-budget warning already ringing in his ears, Bartosz Brzeziński reports.

In Bratislava on Tuesday, Slovak Prime Minister Robert Fico told the European Council chief that Slovakia wants a “strong agricultural policy” and is unhappy with the Commission’s proposed cuts to farming and cohesion.

Watch for who else pushes back. Costa is using the tour to map the national positions he will eventually have to reconcile around the table of leaders. The question is how many other leaders will push back on farm cuts as forcefully as Fico — and how that demand stacks up against defense, security and competitiveness, which Costa says must also sit at the heart of the seven-year budget that starts in 2028.

Rallying allies: Fico said Slovakia will use its presidency of the Visegrád Four — Slovakia, Czechia, Poland and Hungary — to coordinate budget positions. The group plans to meet the Irish premier in the first week of September. Ireland, in its role at the helm of the rotating presidency of the Council of the EU, is expected to put the next budget plan on the table before EU leaders meet in October.

Warm words, no guarantee: Costa didn’t promise to protect the farm envelope. The next budget “must also ensure the effective use” of funding for cohesion and the Common Agricultural Policy, he said, calling both essential to prosperity and balanced development. But he paired that reassurance with a warning that the EU budget must deliver on its priorities “within the limits of finite resources.”

The clock is ticking: Costa wants leaders to reach a political deal by the end of the year. In Bratislava he warned that failure to do so would risk interruptions to EU funding in 2028 and explicitly named farmers among those who would be hit.

On the road: Costa carried on to Tallinn on Tuesday evening; Prague is next on Thursday. His capitals tour wraps Sept. 17.

CROSS-CHANNEL RAIL

TRAIN BONANZA: The number of international trains linking London to the rest of Europe through the Channel Tunnel is on track to more than double by the end of the decade — with a departure from St. Pancras every 15 minutes , Jon Stone reports.

The background: Infrastructure owners have long encouraged a “second operator” to challenge incumbent Eurostar on the routes between London, Paris, Brussels and Amsterdam — and use up excess capacity on the rail line. That seems to finally be happening, with Virgin last week granted track access by the U.K.’s regulator to run services from St. Pancras to the tunnel, a key step toward launching a European operation.

More than they bargained for: It looks increasingly likely that the competition won’t be stopping at two companies. Against expectations, multiple operators are getting in on the act. The number of daily trains looks likely to go from the 25 round-trip services operated daily by Eurostar to 55 by the end of 2030 — around four departures per hour in each direction, or one every 15 minutes.

What really needs sorting: As anyone who has caught a Eurostar recently will be able to tell you, one huge constraint is passenger capacity at St. Pancras’s international terminal, where there is often nowhere to sit once through passport control. Fortunately, this is on its way to being fixed — with architects Hawkins&Brown commissioned to double the passenger capacity there by 2028 and more expansions planned in the 2030s.

Playbook came to Brussels in 2015 and changed how this town starts its day. It has now landed in Canberra: a capital with just as many officials and, until now, no daily briefing of its own. Canberra Playbook: free, daily, radically impartial. Subscribe free .

6 MORE THINGS GETTING US TALKING

METSOLA’S STATE OF THE UNION: European Parliament President Roberta Metsola takes the stage at Italy’s big summer political gathering in Rimini today, where she’ll deliver a rentrée speech spanning migration, wildfires, trade tensions and Ukraine.

SPOTTED IN MOSCOW: CIA Director John Ratcliffe has traveled to Russia for an unannounced visit, CBS News reports .

BRAUN CHARGED: Polish prosecutors have charged far-right MEP Grzegorz Braun with Holocaust denial after he called gas chambers at Auschwitz “fake.”

SCHOLARSHIP TO NOWHERE: Belgium has awarded university scholarships to Palestinian students — but hasn’t given them a way to leave Gaza .

KEMI-NAISSANCE: After a rough start, U.K. Conservative Leader Kemi Badenoch’s personal ratings are soaring — but that hasn’t led to a bump in her party’s standing.

DUTCH OUT: Israel is booting Dutch representatives from the U.S.-backed Gaza coordination center in Kiryat Gat, in response to what Foreign Minister Gideon Sa’ar called a “series of anti-Israel moves” by the Netherlands.

BRUSSELS CORNER

WEATHER: Light rain changing to sunny intervals. High of 27C.

FOUR SUCCESSIVE DAYS OF SHOOTINGS: Another gunman opened fire in Saint-Gilles Monday evening at the square known as “Place des Deux Bancs,” forcing clients of a local pizzeria to seek shelter, Hanne Cokelaere writes. It was the fourth successive day of gun violence in Brussels, the third successive day

in the commune of Saint-Gilles and the second shooting in the same place. On Tuesday afternoon, police said they arrested two suspects who may be linked to some of the shootings.

Blame game: The mayors of Saint-Gilles, Anderlecht and Forest demanded a national action plan against drug violence after meeting Interior Minister Bernard Quintin on Tuesday. Saint-Gilles Mayor Jean Spinette called for more national support, saying he'd been making that request for years. But the Socialist mayor also came under fire from the center-right MR over a short news clip in which he told youngsters who appeared to be dealing drugs that there were police everywhere — something he dismissed as politicians “exploiting the situation,” according to *Le Soir* .

What's next: MPs are expected to grill Quintin and Justice Minister Annelies Verlinden in an extraordinary committee meeting before the summer recess is over, *Belga* reported. The blame game between politicians “hasn't protected anyone,” MP Ismaël Nuino, the president of the justice committee, said. “The population needs a strong and quick response.”

TALK TO PLAYBOOK: On the Brussels Playbook Podcast, Zoya asked about your experiences living in Brussels and whether you've been affected by the spate of shootings. WhatsApp us on +32 491 050629 and listen from 7 a.m. to hear if we give you a shoutout.

TOP OF THE PLAYBOOKS

Berlin: Friedrich Merz's government is preparing to name the perpetrators of the Leipzig drone attack — and weighing several options to deter future hybrid operations.

Paris: Raphaël Glucksmann wants the left's presidential primary to be a formality, but his rivals are pushing for a string of TV debates .

London: Andy Burnham is pushing a plan for more apprenticeships but it's likely to be overshadowed by an increase in household energy bills.

Washington: Senate candidate Abdul El-Sayed's ties to a controversial left-wing Twitch streamer could derail his bid to unite Democrats behind his campaign.

Canberra: Defense experts are worried Australia won't have enough munitions if war breaks out in the Asia-Pacific.

AGENDA

— European Council President António Costa visits Vilnius, where he meets Lithuanian President Gitanas Nausėda, before traveling to Riga for talks with Latvian Prime Minister Andris Kulbergs. Watch .

— European Parliament President Roberta Metsola addresses the 2026 Rimini Meeting in Italy at midday. Follow live .

— Environment Commissioner Jessika Roswall meets Sweden's King Carl XVI Gustaf and Crown Princess Victoria in Stockholm.

— The Council's Working Party on Human Rights (COHOM) meets at 10 a.m.

BIRTHDAYS

MEP Branko Grims; former MEP David Martin; former U.N. High Representative for Bosnia and Herzegovina Christian Schmidt; Agence Europe's Camille-Cerise Gessant; journalists Arthur MacMillan, Miles Herszenhorn and Jamal Halaby; Reformist Movement's Nima Hairy.

Playbook is brought to you by POLITICO's EU Politics team: Gerardo Fortuna, Nicholas Vinocur, Gabriel Gavin, Zoya Sheftalovich, Max Grier, Mari Eccles, Hanne Cokelaere and Sebastian Starcevic. And: reporters Ferdinand Knapp and Milena Wälde, editors Alex Spence and James Panichi, and producers Dean Southwell and Hugh Kapernaros.

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